

Faculty FURORE

IIT faculty want more money and greater autonomy than the HRD Ministry, in full muscle-flexing mode, is ready to give. It's a confrontation with echoes from the past.

| By Nandini Vaish |

Crossing swords with the IITs and the IIMS has not done previous Human Resource Development (HRD) ministers any good. And it is certainly ruffling Kapil Sibal's hitherto smooth exterior. It all began with the ministry's September 16 order which pegged the salary for directors of the IITs and IIMS and faculty members at a much lower scale than they anticipated. They were not expecting to be told that only four out of every 10 professors would be eligible for higher pay after six years. Added to that was the diktat that fresh PhDs would be inducted into the faculty on contract and made permanent only after completing a

certain tenure. It was the signal for a standoff and sure enough, on September 24, some 3,000 members of the All India IIT Faculty Federation (AIFFF) went on a nationwide strike protesting against the pay hike recommended by the Sixth Pay Commission. The ominous words, "autonomy, dignity and honour", that had brought Murli Manohar Joshi to his knees in 2004 over reducing the fees, increasing faculty work hours and student-teacher ratios, and tarnished Arjun Singh's reputation when he insisted on OBC reservation in 2006, were trotted out.

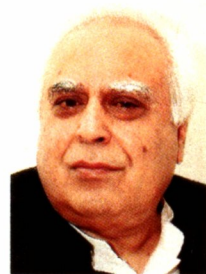
And even as the faculty maintains the fight is on autonomy and not pay, Sibal insists it's all about the money. "If you ask any IIT director, he will tell you that there is more autonomy given to the directors here than anywhere else," says Sibal, adding that he has never

interfered in the working of the IIT Board, even though "we fund them 100 per cent. We too are accountable to Parliament." He has now called for a council meeting between the stakeholders on October 19 to sort out the issues face-to-face. He won't find it easy. IIT autonomy is a sensitive issue as Joshi found out in 2004 and then a year later when the HRD Ministry's decision to do away with the Joint Entrance Examination, impose a cut-off for appearing for the mains and limit the number of entrance exam appearances sparked off a protest. In 2006, the ministry again entered a standoff with the IITs over reservations for OBCs. The ministry had its way with the Supreme Court clearing the Central Educational Institutions (Reservation in Admission) Act, 2006, last year which mandated the IITs, IIMS and other Central educational

**IIT-DELHI FACULTY MEMBERS
STRIKE WORK**



"The faculty should be talking about the way forward for India instead of resorting to whatever they are doing."



KAPIL SIBAL, HRD Minister



"The IIT faculty is governed by law. Even within government rules, enough freedom is available."

SANJAY DHANDE, Director, IIT-Kanpur